A scaled down heat shield of SLV, Rate Gyro Unit, and Vehicle Attitude Programmer were integrated into the Centaur rocket. The three systems involved wide-ranging expertise— composite materials, control engineering and software, none of them ever having been tried before in the country. The test was a complete success. Until then the Indian Space Programme had not gone beyond sounding rockets and even knowledgeable people were not ready to see and acknowledge its efforts as anything more serious than fiddling around with meteorological instruments. For the first time, we inspired the confidence of the nation.

Prime Minister Indira Gandhi told Parliament on 24 July 1974, “The development and fabrication of relevant technologies, subsystems and hardware (to make India’s first Satel ite Launch Vehicle) are progressing satisfactorily. A number of industries are engaged in the fabrication of components. The first orbital flight by India is scheduled to take place in 1978.”

Like any other act of creation, the creation of the SLV-3 also had its painful moments. One day, when my team and I were total y engrossed in the preparation of the static test of the first stage motor, the news of a death in the family